

WHAT I WANT YOU TO KNOW

WHAT I WANT YOU TO KNOW

My stories. My memories. My words.

JOSHUA CALEB GREEN

WORDS TO KEEP

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No part of the printed text of this book may be reproduced without permission from the publisher. Everything written into this book by hand belongs to the person who wrote it, and to whoever they give it to.

This book is meant to be written in. A fine ballpoint or a fine-tip pen shows through the page least.

Series: Words to Keep

This book was given to

BY

ON

Because

If you bought this book for yourself:

This book belongs to

This book is yours.

Someone gave it to you because they want more of you than they have. Not the version they already know. The rest.

There are no rules here. Skip anything. Write two words on a page, or run into the margins. Answer a question with a completely different story, because that's the one that showed up. Tape in a photograph. Draw. Write in pencil and change your mind.

This is not homework. Nobody is grading it. Nobody is even waiting, not really. They're hoping.

Some of these questions will be easy. Some will surprise you. A few will ask for things you've never said out loud. Those are the ones most worth answering, and the ones you are most allowed to leave blank.

Write it in your own hand if you can. Your handwriting is part of what they're keeping.

If you bought this book for yourself, without anyone asking, then you already know why. Somebody is going to want this someday. You're just getting there first.

Start anywhere. Start today if you can.

How to use this book

Any order. Any pace. Any pen. A fine ballpoint or fine-tip pen shows through least.

One question to a page. The important ones get two.

A small mark beside a question means: this one doesn't usually get asked.

Each part ends with a page of quick ones, and a page with a question from your family. That question was written by the person who gave you this book, before they wrapped it.

Where the book says mother, father, child, or family, it means whoever those people were for you.

Blank pages are for photographs, drawings, recipes, or anything the book didn't think to ask for.

You decide who reads this, and when.

If you only fill out ten pages

Few people finish every page of a book like this. If you only do ten, do these.

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You can skip anything.

Any question. Any page. Any part. Nothing in this book is owed. What you leave blank says nothing about you, and what you fill in is yours to fill in any way you like.

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PART ONE

Where I Came From

Start small. The house. The street. The kitchen at six in the morning. Nobody is asking for a history. They're asking what it was like to be you, before anyone called you by the name they call you now.

Some of this you've told before. Tell it again, the long way. Some of it you've never said out loud. That's the part they'll read twice.

The first address you remember.

Then: what the front door looked like from the street.

[illegible]

Where did people actually spend their time?

[illegible]

Who was cooking, and what were they making?

[illegible]

What was she like as a person? What did she want?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Now your father, the same way.

What did he do with his hands? What did he do when he thought no one was looking?

[illegible]

- What did your parents argue about?

Did you understand it then? Do you now?

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Their voices. Their houses. The thing they always said.

[illegible]

Your brothers and sisters, one at a time.

The one you fought with. The one you followed. The one you protected. If you were an only child, who filled those roles?

[illegible]

Family tree

Fill in what you know. Question marks are allowed.

THEIR PARENTS

_____	_____	_____	_____
NAME	NAME	NAME	NAME

MY GRANDPARENTS

_____	_____	_____	_____
NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN

MY PARENTS

_____	_____
NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN

ME

NAME, BORN

MY BROTHERS AND SISTERS

_____	_____	_____	_____
NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN	NAME, BORN

OTHERS WHO COUNTED AS FAMILY

_____	_____	_____	_____
NAME, WHO THEY WERE	NAME, WHO THEY WERE	NAME, WHO THEY WERE	NAME, WHO THEY WERE

And where it went

Add anyone the boxes leave out. Draw lines however you like.

ME, AND THE PERSON I BUILT A LIFE WITH

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

CHILDREN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

GRANDCHILDREN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

NAME, BORN

AND AFTER THAT

[illegible]

The street you grew up on.

Who lived on it? Who did the adults warn you about?

[illegible]

The story your family tells at every gathering.

Now the version that actually happened.

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What were you afraid of when you were small?

What did the adults tell you about it?

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[illegible]

Tell me about a perfectly ordinary day from when you were nine.

Waking up to falling asleep. Leave nothing out.

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Quick ones

Your first phone number.

The sound of a parent coming home.

What your mother called you when you were in trouble.

What your grandmother's house smelled like.

A word your family used that no one else does.

A tradition you assumed every family had.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART TWO

Becoming Me

Somewhere between the child and the adult, there was a person your family has never met. The one who lied about where they were going. The one with a plan. The one who was sure about everything.

This section is for that person. Be honest about them. They turned out fine.

Describe your bedroom at sixteen.

What was on the walls. What was hidden, and from whom.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What did you look like? Be honest.

The hair. The clothes. What you thought you looked like.

[illegible]

Your first job. Not the title. The first day.

Who trained you. What you got wrong. What you did with the first paycheck.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What did you want to be?

What happened to that?

[illegible]

Who was the adult who saw something in you?

What did they say or do?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

The first time you fell in love.

Not the story you tell. What it felt like at the time.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

- What did you get in trouble for?

And what did you get away with that you still haven't told anyone?

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Tell me about leaving home.

What you packed. Who drove. What you didn't say.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Do you remember the day you felt like an adult for the first time?

Not the day you legally became one.

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Finish these

At nineteen, I was sure that

And I was right about

Quick ones

At eighteen, everyone thought I was going to

The record you played too loud.

What you drove, rode, or walked.

The curfew, and how often you broke it.

The skill you faked.

The song from that one summer.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

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For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART THREE

Love & People

Nobody becomes who they are alone. This is where the other people come in. The ones who stayed. The ones who didn't. The person you married, or almost did. The friend whose number you still know by heart.

Some of these pages will be easy. One or two won't. Take them in any order.

Tell me about your oldest friend.

What keeps it going?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Who was the funniest person you ever knew?

Tell me one of their stories, or one of their jokes.

[illegible]

Tell me about a friendship that ended.

What happened? Would you fix it now, if you could?

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Who changed the direction of your life?

Did they know?

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Now tell the version that isn't the polished one. If there wasn't one person, write about whoever came closest.

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Do you remember what you knew on the day you committed to them?

And what you had no idea about?

[illegible]

The important people

Name. Who they were to me. One line I'd want you to know about them.

NAME

WHO THEY WERE TO ME

ONE LINE I'D WANT YOU TO KNOW

NAME

WHO THEY WERE TO ME

ONE LINE I'D WANT YOU TO KNOW

NAME

WHO THEY WERE TO ME

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ONE LINE I'D WANT YOU TO KNOW

NAME

WHO THEY WERE TO ME

ONE LINE I'D WANT YOU TO KNOW

Tell me about a fight you still remember.

What was it really about?

[illegible]

What is a long relationship made of?

Not the advice. The specifics.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

A friend. An animal. A place. A child who wasn't yours.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Tell me about a kind of love you didn't expect. (continued)

[illegible]

Who did you lose too early?

Tell me about them, not about losing them.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Skip this if you want. It's here because nobody asks.

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Quick ones

The friend whose number you still know by heart.

Who you'd call at three in the morning.

The animal you loved most.

Who taught you to drive, and what they said.

Who you owe a phone call.

The best wedding you ever went to.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

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PART FOUR

The Life I Actually Lived

There's the life you planned, and there's this one. Work, money, the moves, the risks, the long stretches where nothing seemed to happen and the single afternoons that changed everything.

Your family knows the outline. They don't know what it felt like from the inside. That's what these pages are for.

What did you actually do all day at work?

Not the title. The Tuesday.

This image shows a single page of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

The worst boss you ever had.

What did they teach you, on purpose or not?

[illegible]

[illegible]

Tell me about the move.

The one that changed everything, or the one you swore you'd never make.

[illegible]

What was the poorest you ever were?

What did it teach you that being comfortable never could?

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What did you build?

A business, a house, a garden, a team, a table.

[illegible]

Tell me about a risk you took.

What was at stake?

[illegible]

- And the risk you didn't take.

The one you still think about.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

Tell someone starting down the same road you took what you wish you'd known. (continued)

[illegible]

What was the luckiest thing that ever happened to you?

Did it feel lucky at the time?

[illegible]

Including you.

[illegible]

What did you want that you didn't get?

What did you get instead?

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Quick ones

The first thing you bought that felt like success.

The job you'd do again for free.

The job you'd never do again.

The thing you're embarrassingly good at.

Your first rent.

The farthest from home you've ever been.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

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For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART FIVE

Becoming a Parent

If you never had children, turn to Part Six. Nothing here is required, and nothing is missing without it.

If you did: nobody tells the truth about this part, mostly because nobody asks. What you expected. What you got. The things you'd do again in a second, and the things you still think about at night. Your children may read this. Tell them anyway.

Tell me about finding out.

Where you were, and the first thing you felt, before the thing you were supposed to feel.

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Finish these

I swore I'd never _____ like my parents did.

And then I

[illegible]

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

The day you realized your child was a whole person, separate from you. (continued)

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

Quick ones

The first word.

The bedtime routine, in order.

What you called them that wasn't their name.

The toy that went everywhere.

The song you sang, whether or not you could sing.

The age you secretly liked best.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

PART SIX

The Hard Stuff

You can skip this whole section. That isn't a formality. It's the rule.

Every life has years it doesn't talk about. You don't owe anyone those years. But if there's something you've carried a long time, and you've ever wished someone knew, this is a place to set it down. Write as much or as little as you want. Stop whenever you like. The book will still be here tomorrow.

Tell me about a loss.

Whoever or whatever it was.

[illegible]

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

What was grief actually like for you?

Not what people say it's like.

[illegible]

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

What was the loneliest stretch of your life?

Did anyone know?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

[illegible]

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

- What did you hide from the people you love, to protect them?

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Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

- Was there a time you almost gave up?

What kept you?

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Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

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Skip this one if you want. Nothing is lost.

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This page can stay blank. It can also be the reason this book exists.

[illegible]

THE HARD STUFF 126

Quick ones

The song that got you through.

The person who called at the right time.

The meal someone brought.

Where you went to be alone.

A sentence someone said that you kept.

The first good day after.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

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For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART SEVEN

Things I Never Said

This is the shortest section in the book, and the one most people will read first when it's their turn.

Everyone has sentences they never finished. Some are apologies. Some are thank-yous. Some are just the truth, waiting for a better moment that never came. Here is the moment. You don't have to say everything. Say one thing.

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[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

This is the moment.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Finish these

I never told you that

I was wrong about

I always meant to

I'm sorry I

Thank you for _____. I don't think I ever said it.

I hope you know that

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

PART EIGHT

What I Believe Now

Not what you were taught. Not what you used to think. What you actually believe, now, after all of it. About money, about love, about what matters and what turned out not to.

You're allowed to have changed your mind. You're allowed to still not know. Both are worth writing down.

[illegible]

Finish these

My parents believed

I kept

I left _____ behind.

[illegible]

Do you remember changing your mind about something big?

What changed it?

[illegible]

What makes a good life?

Not a successful one. A good one.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Being right, or being kind.

Which did you choose more often? Which do you wish you had?

[illegible]

- What were you completely wrong about, for a long time?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

The rule you live by that you've never said out loud. (continued)

[illegible]

Asked plainly. Answer however you like, or not at all.

WHAT I BELIEVE NOW 158

What do you believe happens to a person after they're gone?

Only if you want to.

This image shows a single page of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What I believe, in one line each

About marriage.

About children.

About friends.

About work.

About luck.

About regret.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART NINE

What I'm Proud Of

Most people are bad at this one. They reach for the obvious thing, then feel awkward and stop.

Go past the obvious thing. The pride that counts is usually quieter: something you didn't do, someone you stood by, a day you didn't quit. There's no one here to accuse you of bragging. This is your book.

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[illegible]

Tell me about a small act of courage.

The kind nobody would call courage.

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What do you want on the record? (continued)

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Say it.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Quick ones

A compliment you never forgot.

The thing you fixed.

The habit you broke.

The thing you finished.

The fear you beat.

The meal you're known for.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART TEN

What I Wish I'd Done Differently

Every honest life has a few of these. Writing them down isn't confession and it isn't punishment. It's the most useful thing you can hand to someone younger: here is where I went wrong, and here is what I'd tell you instead.

Be kind to the person who made those choices. They didn't know what you know now.

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What would you have spent more time on?

And less?

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[illegible]

- [illegible]

What have you forgiven yourself for?

And what haven't you?

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Quick ones

The trip you didn't take.

The thing you should have said at a funeral.

The friend you let go quiet.

The thing you'd have learned.

The job you'd have quit sooner.

The worry you'd hand back.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

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For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART ELEVEN

What I Want You to Know

Everything before this was the story. This is the part where you turn and look at the people reading it.

Not everyone at once. Picture one of them. Write to that one. Then, if you want, picture the next. These are the pages they'll come back to.

[illegible]

What I'm proud of you for.

It has nothing to do with what you've achieved.

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[illegible]

[illegible]

This image shows a single page of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page, leaving small margins at the top and bottom. There are no vertical margin lines, and the page is completely blank except for the lines themselves.

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[illegible]

Family sayings

What we always said. What it meant.

WE ALWAYS SAID

WHAT IT MEANT

WE ALWAYS SAID

WHAT IT MEANT

WE ALWAYS SAID

WHAT IT MEANT

WE ALWAYS SAID

WHAT IT MEANT

WE ALWAYS SAID

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WHAT IT MEANT

WE ALWAYS SAID

What to do when life gets hard.

Not advice. What worked for me.

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Who I hope you become.

Not what. Who.

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[illegible]

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A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART TWELVE

When You Miss Me

Someday the people who love you will want to feel close to you and you won't be in the next room. This isn't a sad section. It's a practical one.

Tell them where to find you. The song, the road, the recipe, the thing you always said. Give them something to do with their hands. Give them a reason to laugh at exactly the moment they need one.

The song to play.

And the one to skip, because it will wreck you.

[illegible]

The songs

Title. Who sang it. Why.

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

WHY

TITLE, AND WHO SANG IT

The place to go.

Give directions.

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The thing to cook.

Tell me what it should taste like.

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The recipe

One recipe, in your handwriting. Include the part that isn't written down anywhere.

WHAT IT'S CALLED

WHO TAUGHT IT TO ME

WHAT GOES IN IT

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The joke to tell.

Tell it badly, the way I do.

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Not a sunset. Something with a brand name. Or a smell.

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The small thing of mine to keep.

And why that one.

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[illegible]

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- What I don't want you to do.

Don't keep the house like a museum. Don't _____.

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Don't.

[illegible]

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Quick ones

My coffee order.

The word I always mispronounced.

The show I'd never admit to watching.

What I always said at the door.

My favorite way to waste an afternoon.

What to do on my birthday.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

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PART THIRTEEN

Letters

There are no prompts here. Just the names of the people you love, and room.

Write one letter or all of them. Write them badly. Cross things out. A letter in your handwriting, with your mistakes in it, will be worth more to them than anything perfect.

The last letter is for whoever needs it, whenever they need it. Take your time with that one.

To my child

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

To my child

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

To my child

TO

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no text or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

To the person I built a life with

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

To my grandchildren

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

To my family

TO

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no text or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

To those who come after me

TO

[illegible]

[illegible]

One last letter

TO

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no text or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

In my own hand

Write your name the way you sign it.

Write the sentence you say most.

Write one word you want them to have.

SIGNED

DATE

For the one reading this

*You are holding someone's own words, in their own hand, written
for you. Not everything in here is finished. That's what makes it
true.*

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